

Hackles Club: Out-of-School Edition. Start Here for Club Leaders

The Hackles Kit

Trust your hackles. Pause · Check · Tell.

FIELD COPY



PLATE I. The six strands, hand-inked, in the order the lessons take them.

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[Logo: Hackles]

HACKLES CLUB

Trust your hackles. *Pause · Check · Tell*

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Status: DRAFT. Items marked [VERIFY] need checking against a primary source. Items marked [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM] need a lawyer, or your organisation's HR and safeguarding lead, before you rely on them. This guide is general educational material and not legal advice.

No child accounts, no child data collected, ever. Everything in the Club runs on paper, pencils, a timer and people.

01 Welcome

YOU VOLUNTEERED TO SPEND some hours with kids, and you don't have to be a technology person to do it well. If you can read a card out loud in a silly voice, say "Nice noticing!", and stay calm when a child says something surprising, you can run a Hackles Club.

Your hackles are the hairs that rise on the back of your neck when something feels off. A Hackles Club teaches kids to notice that feeling and do something sensible with it:

- 1. **Hackles up?** Something feels odd, too good, pushy, secret or scary.
- 2. **Pause.** Stop. Do nothing yet.
- 3. **Check.** Is it real? Who is it from? What do they want?
- 4. **Tell.** A trusted adult, every time, with no shame.

Two promises go at the start of every session, out loud: **"A false alarm is fine. It is never your fault."** A child who gets tricked was tricked by the person who did the tricking, and a child who says "my hackles are up" about something harmless did exactly the right thing.

THE CREW (WHO YOU WILL MEET)

CHARACTER	JOB	LOOK
Hackle	The "tingly uh-oh" detector. Host of every session. They/them.	Baby hedgehog with pale-yellow, tangerine-tipped quills that stand up when something is off
Latch	Passwords	Friendly mint padlock with a keyhole smile
Peeper	Spotting scams and fakes	Big-eyed sky-blue critter with a magnifying glass
Pip	Privacy: what to share and what to keep in the shell	Little coral hermit-crab
Buddy	Trusted adults	Gentle grape-colored bear with a heart badge
Ember	Kindness, calm and screen breaks	Warm teal flame sprite
Fixit	Oops recovery and telling	Tangerine helper robot with a toolbelt
Rinse	The calm, no-blame chat after an oops ("what happened and what do we do next"). A supporting-cast character in the Character Bible, so use the name only if it is in your printed materials.	A raccoon
Gifty, the Too-Good Box	The silly trickster in games and puppet shows	Gold gift box with a hook on the bow. Always an adult voice. Never scary, never wins.

[VERIFY the current spelling and roles against the Character Bible before printing.]

02 What a Hackles Club is

A HACKLES CLUB IS a short series of games-first sessions for **6 to 25 kids** that a volunteer leader can run without a classroom, a screen, a budget or a teaching certificate.

SPECIMEN LABEL	
SESSIONS	6 sessions of 45 to 60 minutes (the Club), or 8 sessions (the Summer Camp version)
GROUP SIZE	6 to 25 kids, split into teams of 3 to 5
DEVICES	None. No child ever logs in to anything.
COST	Under \$10 for a whole Club, because you probably own the paper and pencils [VERIFY prices locally]
AGES	Three tracks: 5-7, 8-11 and 12-15
SETTING	Libraries, troops and clubs, after-school programs, summer camps, faith-community youth groups, homeschool co-ops
LEADERS	Two adults at every session, neither of them required to be a teacher

WHAT KIDS LEARN

Scams and fake offers, passwords and passphrases, privacy basics (what's fun to share and what stays in the shell), kind behaviour online, telling a trusted adult, and the Help Ladder: a friend you trust, then a trusted adult, then a report tool, and keep climbing until someone helps.

WHAT A CLUB IS NOT

A Club is a set of games. It does not replace a school counselor, a doctor or the authorities. It does not cover sextortion, grooming, trafficking or any sexual content, because those topics need trained professionals and a family conversation. See Section 7.

03 Choose your track

TRACK	AGES	NAME	GAMES YOU WILL PLAY	FILE
A	5-7	Little Hackles	Spot the Fishy (hand signals), Pause Palm Freeze, puppets, Trail Walk on the floor, read-alouds	02_Track_A_Ages_5-7.md
B	8-11	Hands-On Hackers	Spot the Fishy "Pond Patrol", Passphrase Vault, Help Ladder climb, Quiet Door missions, role-plays	03_Track_B_Ages_8-11.md
C	12-15	Case Files	Phish Lab Live, Account Vault, footprint detective, source check, Stand-With role-plays, teen-led Hackles Day	04_Track_C_Ages_12-15.md

Mixed ages? Use the Homeschool Co-op plan (07) or the Family Night kit (05). If a 5-year-old and a 14-year-old have to share one room, pair them as buddies, with the older one reading the card and the younger one giving the first answer.

OTHER FORMATS IN THIS FOLDER

WHAT	FILE
Printable card sets for all tracks	01_Club_Card_Sets.md
90-minute family night with stations	05_Family_Night_Kit.md
Hackles Patch skills checklist	06_Hackles_Patch_Skills_Checklist.md
12-week homeschool co-op plan	07_Homeschool_Co-op_12_Week_Plan.md
90-minute orientation for new leaders	08_Leader_Orientation_90_Minutes.md
Registration, letters, permission slip, schedule, sign-in, impact tally	09 to 12
Certificate and badge design brief	13_Certificate_and_Badge_Design_Brief.md
Library toolkit	14_Library_Toolkit.md

04 What a leader needs

THE SHORT LIST

- **Two adults** at every session (Section 5).
- A **completed screening and training** per your organisation's policy [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM].
- **One 90-minute orientation** (file 08) before your first session.
- **The session page printed**, the cards cut, and the supplies for that session (each track lists them).
- A **trusted-adult contact** at your host organisation: someone who knows what to do if a child tells you something serious. Write the name and number on the card in Section 6 before the first session.
- A **calm voice**, and a sense of humor for the moment a six-year-old explains the plot of a video game for four minutes.

THE SHAPE OF EVERY SESSION

MINUTES	PART	WHAT HAPPENS
5	Gather	Name tags (first names only, optional), the two promises, the Hackles chant
5	Warm-up game	A quick movement game
15 to 20	Main game	The session's game, played in teams
8 to 10	Talk and practice	Short role-play or "how would you say it" practice with the Tell sentence
3 to 5	Calm-down or screen-break moment	Ember's Warm Breath, stretching, or a quiet drawing
5	Close	Take-home family card, Hackles Up, Pause, Check, Tell, and the Tell Wave

A 45-MINUTE SESSION DROPS the warm-up and shortens the talk. A 60-minute session adds the camp stretch at the end of the session page.

HOW TO LEAD IF YOU ARE NOT AN EXPERT

- Read the **Leader script** lines out loud, exactly as written. They're short on purpose, so you won't have to improvise.
- Say **"I don't know. Let's check together"** whenever you do not know. That is the Pause and Check in action.
- Never make a child read aloud, share a real password, or tell a personal story. Not even a small one.
- **Never ask a child to play the trickster.** Gifty and every scammer are voiced by an adult from a card.
- Keep a **Parking Lot** on a sheet of paper for questions you'll answer later, or pass on to a family.

05 Safe-adult requirements

FIELD NOTE

No. 1

[COUNSEL TO CONFIRM] Everything in this section is a model for discussion. Your host organisation's safeguarding policy, your insurer, and the law where you live decide what is required. Where this section and your policy differ, follow your policy, and tell your organisation's safeguarding lead that the two should be aligned.

THE TWO-ADULT RULE

AT EVERY SESSION, AT least **two screened adults** are present and awake to the whole room. If only one leader arrives, the session doesn't run, or it moves to a public space with other adults in clear sight. A parent or another adult who has not been screened does not count as one of the two unless your policy says so [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM].

NEVER ONE-ON-ONE

- No adult is ever alone with a child, in a room, a car, a hallway or a message thread.
- When a child needs a private word, move to a spot that is private for the child and visible to the second adult: a table at the edge of the room, or a doorway with the door open.
- No adult is a child's friend or follower on any personal account. No texting, messaging or calling a child directly. All contact goes through the child's parent or guardian and the host organisation's channel.
- No giving rides, and no gifts to individual children. Group prizes and certificates are fine.

SCREENING AND TRAINING

- Screening for leaders follows your organisation's policy: background check, reference check, application, interview, and a signed code of conduct [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM what is required where you live and for your type of organisation].
- A leader completes the 90-minute orientation (file 08) and re-reads this guide each term.
- Teen helpers (aged 14 and up, if your policy allows) never count as one of the two adults and are never left alone with younger children [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM].

PHOTOS AND RECORDING

- **Default: no photos of children at all.** The Club doesn't need them.
- If your organisation wants photos, written permission is collected by the host organisation first. Take photos only on an organisation device, never on a leader's personal phone, and never at the Tell-Someone Booth or during any role-play about telling.
- Never post a child's name with a picture. Never post a child's picture at all unless the host organisation's media policy and the family's written permission both cover it [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM].
- Never record audio or video of a session.
- If a parent photographs their own child at a family night, ask them to keep other families' children out of the frame.

REPORTING DUTY

Many places require adults who work or volunteer with children to report suspected abuse or neglect, and some make every adult a reporter. Who counts, how fast, and to whom all vary by location.

- **Your local reporting rule:** [FILL IN: your state, province or country law and the number to call] [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM]
- **Your organisation's safeguarding lead:** [FILL IN name and phone]
- **Local child protection line:** [FILL IN]
- **Emergency number:** [FILL IN: 911 in the United States and Canada, or your local number]
- **Mental health crisis line:** [FILL IN: 988 in the United States [VERIFY]]

A leader reports personally when the law says so, and because telling the host organisation's manager may not satisfy your own duty, you should ask your safeguarding lead the same hour whenever you're unsure whether something meets the threshold. Suspicion is usually enough to trigger a report. Proof is not required [VERIFY for your location; COUNSEL TO CONFIRM].

06 If a child tells you something (print this card)

Keep this card in your session folder. Both adults read it before the first session.

DO	DO NOT
Stay calm. Soften your voice. Keep your face neutral.	Show shock, anger or panic.
Say: "Thank you for telling me. This is not your fault. You are not in trouble."	Say: "Why did you...?" "You should have...?"
Move to a spot that is private for the child and visible to the second adult.	Be alone behind a closed door with a child.
Listen. Use open prompts: "Tell me more." "What happened next?"	Ask leading questions or press for detail.
Be honest: "I can't keep this a secret, because I need to get you help. I will tell you who I tell."	Promise secrecy. Promise how it will turn out.
Write down the child's exact words afterward, with the date and time.	Investigate, confront anyone, or contact the person named.
Tell your safeguarding lead the same day, or at once if a child is in danger. Report personally if the law requires it.	Assume telling the lead is enough, until you have checked your local rule.
If a device holds pictures, do not look at, copy, forward or screenshot them.	Ask the child to show you.
If a child may hurt themselves, stay with them and call your crisis line or emergency number right away.	Leave the child alone.

Your contacts (fill in before session 1):

- Safeguarding lead: _____ Phone: _____
- Local child protection line: _____
- Emergency number: _____ Crisis line: _____

Say it like this: "Thank you for telling me. I believe you. It is not your fault. I need to share this with people whose job is to keep kids safe, and I will tell you who. You do not have to handle this alone."

After a disclosure, look after the child and look after yourself, and tell your lead how you're doing. You are not the investigator and you are not the therapist. You are the safe adult who listened, and that is the whole job.

For the full guide, see the Disclosure and Incident Guide in [kit/05_Teacher_Support/](#). It was written for teachers. Where it says "your school", read "your host organisation".

07 What a Club does not cover

FIELD NOTE

No. 2

Sensitive-topic rule: Club content stays at the level of the kit's general lessons: scams, passwords, privacy basics, kind behaviour online, telling a trusted adult and the Help Ladder.

A CLUB LEADER DOES not teach, role-play or answer detailed questions about:

- Sextortion, nude or sexual images, or pressure to send pictures.
- Grooming, or how an adult might win a child's trust to harm them.
- Trafficking or exploitation.
- Self-harm, suicide or other mental-health crises.
- Violence, threats or revenge.

Why not. These topics need a trained adult, a way to follow up with each child, and a family conversation, and a Club leader has none of the three, whereas the kit's school lessons on these topics come with a counselor, an opt-out process and a disclosure plan.

What you do instead.

1. **Thank the child or the family** for asking. Never shame a question.
2. **Say the honest limit:** "That is an important question. It is not one we cover in this Club. The school counselor or a trusted grown-up at home is the right person, and I will help you find them."
3. **Refer the family** to the school counselor, or to the resources in the Disclosure and Incident Guide (kit/05_Teacher_Support/), or to your host organisation's safeguarding lead.
4. If the question sounds like something that **has happened to the child**, use the "If a child tells you something" card (Section 6) and tell your safeguarding lead the same day.
5. **Never improvise** an answer. Never promise secrecy.

The card sets leave out stranger-contact and private-chat scenarios for this reason. If a family wants that conversation, the Family Engagement Pack (kit/06_Family/) has a letter and a "what to do if your child tells you something scary" page.

08 Inclusion and fairness

- **Every family is a family.** Say "a grown-up you trust" and never "your mom and dad". Draw trusted adults as any family: two dads, a grandparent, a carer, a coach.
- **Every child can pass.** A Pass card sits on the table at every session. Nobody explains why they used it.
- **Every child can play without reading, writing, speaking, standing or hearing.** Each session lists a quiet, seated, or no-reading way to join. Ask families what a child needs on the registration form, in the child's own words if they want.
- **No elimination, no losing.** Every game is cooperative, and the whole group fills the Pond or walks the Trail together.
- **Color is never the only clue.** Cards carry words and symbols as well.
- **Devices at home vary.** Some families have none, some have many. Never ask what a child has at home. Say "if your family uses a phone or tablet".
- **Language.** Use short sentences, say each instruction twice, and show it with your hands. If your families speak other languages, ask a volunteer to translate the take-home cards. The Hackles team does not provide translations for this folder [VERIFY].
- **Faith and culture.** Hackles is about noticing and telling, and it does not tell any family how to run its home.
- **Never use a real incident,** a real message, a real child's name or a real password in any game.

FOR MORE, SEE THE Inclusion and Equity Guide in [kit/05_Teacher_Support/](#).

09 Setting up your first session: a 20-minute checklist

- ☐ Two screened adults are confirmed. Names are on the sign-in sheet.
- ☐ Both adults have read Sections 5, 6 and 7 of this guide.
- ☐ The safeguarding contact card is filled in and in the folder.
- ☐ Registration forms are collected by the host organisation (file 09). You do not keep child data.
- ☐ The parent letter and permission slip are out (file 10).
- ☐ The room has a door that opens, visible space and a quiet corner.
- ☐ The session page is printed. The cards are cut.
- ☐ Supplies for the session are on the table.
- ☐ A Pass card and a tissue box are on the table.
- ☐ Pencils, a timer, a clipboard for the adult sign-in sheet.
- ☐ The Parking Lot sheet is on the wall.
- ☐ A first-aid kit and the building's exit routes are known.

10 Where this Club comes from

THE CLUB IS BUILT from the Hackles classroom kit, which was written for teachers. The games are from the Games and Fun Pack (Spot the Fishy, The Hackles Trail, Mission: Quiet Door, read-alouds, songs, puppets, bingo and passports). The unplugged demos are from the Concepts Lab. The safety scripts are from the Disclosure and Incident Guide and the Family Engagement Pack. Hackles Day is the school event from the Hackles Day Event Plan, shrunk to fit a room.

Feedback, corrections and ideas are welcome: [CONTACT: to be added].

Hackles is the first step on a learning path that continues with free resources such as picoCTF and CYBER.ORG. (This note is for adults only. It does not appear in any child-facing page.)